

Anselm

Therefore, Lord, You who grant understanding to faith, grant that I may understand (to the extent that You understand it [to be] advantageous) that You exist as we believe, and are that which we believe. And indeed we believe You to be something than which nothing greater can be thought. Or is there not anything of such a nature, since *The fool has said in his heart, 'There is no God'*? But surely this same fool, when he hears this very [thing] that I say, “something than which nothing greater can be thought,” understands what he hears, and what he understands exists in his understanding, even if he does not understand it to exist. For it is one matter for a thing to exist in the understanding, and another matter to understand a thing to exist. For when a painter thinks in advance of what [things] he is going to make, he has them at least in his understanding, but he does not yet understand them to exist. But once he has painted them, he both has what he has now made in his understanding and understands that they exist. Thus, even the fool is convinced that there exists at least in his understanding something than which nothing greater can be thought, because when he hears this he understands it, and whatever is understood exists in the understanding. And certainly that than which a greater cannot be thought cannot exist in the understanding only. For if it exists in the understanding only, it can be thought to exist in reality also, which is greater. If therefore that than which a greater cannot be thought exists in the understanding only, this very [thing] than which a greater cannot be thought is [something] than which a greater *can* be thought. But certainly this cannot be. There exists, therefore, without doubt, something than which a greater cannot be thought—both in the understanding and in reality.

Descartes

*Arguments
proving the existence of God and the distinction
between the soul and the body
arranged in geometrical fashion*

DEFINITIONS

IX. When we say that something is *contained in the nature or concept* of a thing, this is the same as saying that it is true of that thing, or that it can be asserted of that thing.

AXIOMS OR COMMON NOTIONS

X. Existence is contained in the idea or concept of every single thing, since we cannot conceive of anything except as existing. Possible or contingent existence is contained in the concept of a limited thing, whereas necessary and perfect existence is contained in the concept of a supremely perfect being.

PROPOSITION I

*The existence of God can be known
merely by considering his nature*

Demonstration

To say that something is contained in the nature or concept of a thing is the same as saying that it is true of that thing (Def. IX). But necessary existence is contained in the concept of God (Axiom X). Therefore it may be truly affirmed of God that necessary existence belongs to him, or that he exists.

This is the syllogism which I employed above in replying to the sixth point in your Objections. And its conclusion can be grasped as self-evident by those who are free of preconceived opinions, as I said above, in the Fifth Postulate. But since it is not easy to arrive at such clear mental vision, we shall now endeavour to establish the same result by other methods.

PRINCIPLES OF PHILOSOPHY

PART ONE

The Principles of Human Knowledge

[...]

14. *The existence of God is validly inferred from the fact that necessary existence is included in our concept of God.*

The mind next considers the various ideas which it has within itself, and finds that there is one idea—the idea of a supremely intelligent, supremely powerful and supremely perfect being—which stands out from all the others. <And it readily judges from what it perceives in this idea, that God, who is the supremely perfect being, is, or exists. For although it has distinct ideas of many other things it does not observe anything in them to guarantee the existence of their object.> In this one idea the mind recognizes existence—not merely the possible and contingent existence which belongs to the ideas of all the other things which it distinctly perceives, but utterly necessary and eternal existence. Now on the basis of its perception that, for example, it is necessarily contained in the idea of a triangle that its three angles should equal two right angles, the mind is quite convinced that a triangle does have three angles equalling two right angles. In the same way, simply on the basis of its perception that necessary and eternal existence is contained in the idea of a supremely perfect being, the mind must clearly conclude that the supreme being does exist.

15. *Our concepts of other things do not similarly contain necessary existence, but merely contingent existence.*

The mind will be even more inclined to accept this if it considers that it cannot find within itself an idea of any other thing such that necessary existence is seen to be contained in the idea in this way. And from this it understands that the idea of a supremely perfect being is not an idea which was invented by the mind, or which represents some chimera, but that it represents a true and immutable nature which cannot but exist, since necessary existence is contained within it.

16. *Preconceived opinions prevent the necessity of the existence of God from being clearly recognized by everyone.*

Our mind will, as I say, easily accept this, provided that it has first of all completely freed itself from preconceived opinions. But we have got into the habit of distinguishing essence from existence in the case of all other things; and we are also in the habit of making up at will various ideas of things which do not exist anywhere and have never done so. Hence, at times when we are not intent on the contemplation of the supremely perfect being, a doubt may easily arise as to whether the idea of God is not one of those which we made up at will, or at least one of those which do not include existence in their essence.

Kant, Critique of Pure Reason

I would have hoped to annihilate this over-subtle argumentation without any digressions through a precise determination of the concept of existence, if I had not found that the illusion consisting in the confusion of a logical predicate with a real one (i.e., the determination of a thing) nearly precludes all instruction. Anything one likes can serve as a **logical predicate**, even the subject can be predicated of itself; for logic abstracts from every content. But the **determination** is a predicate, which goes beyond the concept of the subject and enlarges it. Thus it must not be included in it already.

Being is obviously not a real predicate, i.e., a concept of something that could add to the concept of a thing. It is merely the positing” of a thing or of certain determinations in themselves. In the logical use it is merely the copula of a judgment. The proposition **God is omnipotent** contains two concepts that have their objects: God and omnipotence; the little word “**is**” is not a predicate in it, but only that which posits the predicate in relation to the subject. Now if I take the subject (God) together with all his predicates (among which omnipotence belongs), and say **God is**, or there is a God, then I add no new predicate to the concept of God, but only posit the subject in itself with all its predicates, and indeed posit the **object** in relation to my **concept**. Both must contain exactly the same, and hence when I think this object as given absolutely (through the expression, “it is”), nothing is thereby added to the concept, which expresses merely its possibility. Thus the actual contains nothing more than the merely possible. A hundred actual dollars do not contain the least bit more than a hundred possible ones. For since the latter signifies the concept and the former its object and its positing in itself, then, in case the former contained more than the latter, my concept would not express the entire object and thus would not be the suitable concept of it. But in my financial condition there is more with a hundred actual dollars than with the mere concept of them (i.e., their possibility). For with actuality the object is not merely included in my concept analytically, but adds synthetically to my concept (which is a determination of my state); yet the hundred dollars themselves that I am thinking of are not in the least increased through this being outside my concept.

Frege, Grundlagen

§ 53. By properties which are asserted of a concept I naturally do not mean the characteristics which make up the concept. These latter are properties of the things which fall under the concept, not of the concept. Thus “rectangular” is not a property of the concept “rectangular triangle”; but the proposition that there exists no rectangular equilateral rectilinear triangle does state a property of the concept “rectangular equilateral rectilinear triangle”; it assigns to it the number nought. In this respect existence is analogous to number. Affirmation of existence is in fact nothing but denial of the number nought. Because existence is a property of concepts the ontological argument for the existence of God breaks down. But oneness is not a component characteristic of the concept “God” any more than existence is. Oneness cannot be used in the definition of this concept any more than the solidity of a house, or its commodiousness or desirability, can be used in building it along with the beams, bricks and mortar.

Russell, “On Denoting”

“The most perfect Being has all perfections; existence is a perfection; therefore the most perfect Being exists” becomes:—

“There is one and only one entity x which is most perfect; that one has all perfections; existence is a perfection; therefore that one exists”. As a proof, this fails for want of a proof of the premiss “there is one and only one entity x which is most perfect”.